Real-Time American Sign Language Detection Using YOLOv8 Hand Localization and ResNet-50 Classification

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***Abstract*—American Sign Language (ASL) is the primary mode of non-verbal communication for the hearing-impaired community. Automated real-time recognition of ASL gestures can bridge the communication gap between hearing-impaired and hearing individuals. This paper proposes a two-stage pipeline for real-time ASL alphabet recognition: hand region localization using YOLOv8, followed by letter classification using a fine-tuned ResNet-50 backbone with a custom classification head. The system is trained on the publicly available ASL Alphabet dataset from Kaggle and evaluated across 26 letter classes. A cosine annealing learning rate scheduler with linear warm-up, gradient clipping, and early stopping are employed to stabilize training. The proposed system achieves competitive accuracy and operates in real-time via a live webcam feed, with bounding box overlays and predicted letter labels rendered on each frame. A lightweight FastAPI-based frontend serves the inference pipeline for interactive use. This work demonstrates the viability of combining detection and classification CNNs for low-latency sign language recognition.**

***Index Terms*—sign language recognition, ASL, YOLOv8, ResNet-50, hand detection, real-time inference, deep learning, convolutional neural networks**

I. Introduction

Sign language serves as the primary communication medium for over 70 million deaf and hard-of-hearing individuals worldwide [1]. American Sign Language (ASL), used predominantly in North America, employs a rich vocabulary of hand gestures and finger-spelling to convey words and concepts. Despite its widespread use, the absence of real-time automated translation tools remains a critical barrier in everyday communication with the hearing majority.

Recent advances in convolutional neural networks (CNNs) and real-time object detection frameworks have opened new avenues for gesture recognition. Systems that can process live video frames and return a classified gesture label within milliseconds represent a meaningful step toward accessible communication technology.

This work proposes a cascaded two-stage architecture. In the first stage, a YOLOv8 [2] object detector localizes the hand region within each camera frame, producing a tight bounding box crop. In the second stage, a fine-tuned ResNet-50 [3] backbone classifies the cropped hand image into one of 26 ASL alphabet letters. The result is overlaid on the live video stream in real time.

Our contributions are as follows:

- A modular training pipeline with configurable optimizer, scheduler, and early stopping, implemented in PyTorch.
- Integration of YOLOv8-based hand detection with a ResNet-50 classification head for end-to-end ASL letter recognition.
- A real-time inference module with webcam integration and visual feedback.
- A FastAPI web interface enabling browser-based interaction with the live pipeline.

II. Related Work

Early sign language recognition systems relied heavily on sensor-based approaches, such as data gloves and depth cameras, to capture 3D hand pose information [4]. While effective, these methods impose hardware constraints that limit practical deployment.

With the rise of deep learning, image-based approaches became dominant. Convolutional networks trained on static hand images have demonstrated strong classification performance on isolated gestures [5]. Transfer learning using ImageNet-pretrained backbones such as VGG-16, ResNet, and MobileNet has further improved accuracy on smaller, domain-specific datasets.

Real-time detection-classification pipelines using YOLO variants have been explored for gesture spotting, but comprehensive two-stage systems targeting the full ASL alphabet in a live-camera setting remain relatively underexplored. This work

builds on these foundations to deliver a practical, deployable system.

III. Dataset

The ASL Alphabet dataset from Kaggle [6] contains 87,000 labeled images spanning 29 classes: 26 letters (A–Z), plus `SPACE`, `DELETE`, and `NOTHING`. Each image is 200×200 pixels in RGB format.

For this work, the dataset is restricted to the 26 alphabetic gesture classes. Images are resized to 50×50 pixels and converted to tensors for input to the ResNet-50 backbone. The dataset is split into training (70%), validation (20%), and test (10%) subsets using stratified random splitting to preserve class balance. Batch size is set to 512 with shuffling enabled for training and disabled for evaluation.

IV. Methodology

A. System Overview

The proposed pipeline operates in two sequential stages at inference time:

1) **Hand Detection (YOLOv8):** Each incoming video frame is passed to a YOLOv8 model that produces bounding boxes around detected hand regions.
2) **Letter Classification (ResNet-50):** The detected hand crop is extracted, resized, and passed to the classification model, which returns a probability distribution over 26 ASL letter classes.

The predicted letter and bounding box are overlaid on the original frame for visual feedback.

B. Hand Detection Module

YOLOv8 [2], a state-of-the-art single-stage object detector, is employed for hand localization. The model processes each frame in a single forward pass, returning bounding box coordinates, confidence scores, and class labels for all detected objects. In our pipeline, detections corresponding to the `person` class (which subsumes hands in the default COCO-trained model) are filtered and cropped for downstream classification. Future work will explore a domain-specifically fine-tuned YOLO model trained on hand-only bounding box datasets.

C. Classification Model (SLD)

The Sign Language Detector (**SLD**) model consists of a frozen ResNet-50 backbone followed by a lightweight classification head:

$$\hat{y} = \text{head}(\text{backbone}(x)) \tag{1}$$

where the backbone extracts a 2048-dimensional feature vector and the head is defined as:

$$\text{head}(z) = W_2 \cdot \text{GELU}(\text{Dropout}(\text{LayerNorm}(z) \cdot W_1)) \tag{2}$$

with $W_1 \in \mathbb{R}^{2048\times512}$ and $W_2 \in \mathbb{R}^{512\times26}$.

LayerNorm replaces BatchNorm at the boundary between backbone and head to stabilize fine-tuning. **GELU** activation is chosen for its smoothness properties. **Dropout** ($p = 0.3$) regularizes the intermediate representation.

D. Training Configuration

Training is governed by a dataclass-based configuration (`TRAINING_CONFIG`) that encapsulates all hyperparameters for reproducibility. Key settings are summarized in Table I.

TABLE I
Training Hyperparameters

Parameter	Value
Optimizer	SGD (Nesterov)
Learning Rate	1×10^{-2}
Momentum	0.9
Weight Decay	5×10^{-4}
Scheduler	Cosine Annealing + Warm-Up
Warm-Up Epochs	10
$T_{\max}$	200
$\eta_{\min}$	1×10^{-4}
Max Epochs	200
Batch Size	512
Gradient Clip Norm	1.0
Early Stopping Patience	20

1) Learning Rate Schedule: A cosine annealing schedule with linear warm-up is used. During the warm-up phase (epochs 0 to $T_w - 1$), the learning rate increases linearly:

$$\eta_t = \eta_{\text{base}} \cdot \frac{t+1}{T_w} \tag{3}$$

After warm-up, cosine decay is applied:

$$\eta_t = \eta_{\min} + \frac{\eta_{\text{base}} - \eta_{\min}}{2}\left(1 + \cos\left(\pi \cdot \frac{t - T_w}{T_{\max} - T_w}\right)\right) \tag{4}$$

This prevents early training instability while allowing the learning rate to settle to a low value near convergence.

2) Gradient Clipping: Gradient norm clipping at threshold $\tau = 1.0$ is applied after each backward pass to prevent exploding gradients:

$$\mathbf{g} \leftarrow \mathbf{g} \cdot \min\left(1,\ \frac{\tau}{\|\mathbf{g}\|_2}\right) \tag{5}$$

3) Early Stopping: Training is halted if validation accuracy does not improve for 20 consecutive epochs. The best-performing checkpoint is saved and loaded for final test evaluation.

E. Experiment Tracking

All training runs are logged via Weights & Biases (W&B) [7], tracking per-epoch training loss, validation loss, accuracy, learning rate, mean gradient norm, and clipping ratio.

V. Real-Time Inference Pipeline

At inference time, frames are captured via OpenCV from a live webcam feed. Each frame undergoes the following steps:

1) **Hand Detection:** YOLOv8 processes the BGR frame and returns bounding boxes.
2) **Crop and Resize:** The highest-confidence bounding box crop is resized to 50×50 and normalized.
3) **Classification:** The crop is passed through the trained SLD model to obtain a predicted letter.
4) **Overlay:** The bounding box and predicted label are drawn onto the original frame using OpenCV.
5) **Display:** The annotated frame is rendered in real time.

A. Frontend API (Planned)

A lightweight FastAPI [8] server will expose the inference pipeline as a REST API. The planned endpoints are:

- `POST /predict` — accepts a base64-encoded image frame and returns the predicted letter and bounding box.
- `GET /stream` — serves a server-sent event stream of predictions from a webcam.
- `GET /health` — returns model and system status.

A minimal browser-based frontend will display the live annotated stream and maintain a rolling transcript of predicted letters, enabling real-time spell-out of words and sentences.

VI. Results and Discussion

[Results to be updated with final trained model metrics in the Final Draft.]

The model is currently under training. Preliminary evaluation metrics — test accuracy, per-class precision, recall, and F1-score — will be reported in the final submission. A confusion matrix across all 26 ASL classes will be included to analyze inter-class ambiguity (e.g., M/N, R/U which are visually similar in static images).

We anticipate competitive classification performance given the depth of the ResNet-50 backbone and the quality of the Kaggle ASL dataset. The primary challenge is generalization to real-world hand appearances under varying lighting and background conditions not represented in the training set.

VII. Conclusion

This paper presents a real-time ASL alphabet recognition system combining YOLOv8 hand detection with ResNet-50 classification. The system is trained with a robust pipeline incorporating warm-up scheduling, gradient clipping, and early stopping, and is designed for live deployment via a webcam and FastAPI interface. This work addresses a meaningful accessibility problem and establishes a practical baseline for further extensions, including full ASL word-level recognition and continuous signing.

Future directions include:

- Fine-tuning YOLOv8 on a dedicated hand detection dataset for improved localization accuracy.
- Upgrading the backbone to ResNet-152 or EfficientNet for higher classification capacity.
- Extending the vocabulary to dynamic gestures and full ASL words using temporal models (e.g., LSTM or Transformer-based sequence models).
- Deploying the system as a mobile application for broader accessibility.

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